



BEFORE

Although the Northern states had a large pool of manpower to draw on, they had difficulty in fulfilling the demand for soldiers in a long war.

A VOLUNTEER ARMY

The Union army was initially a wholly volunteer force. A commitment to 90 days' service quickly proving inadequate, recruits were mostly required to **sign up for three years**, although some two-year volunteers were enrolled in certain states. The **attractions of army service declined** sharply as the risks and hardships of military life became more widely understood, and an **economic boom**—stimulated by the war—made **well-paid civilian work** readily available.

CONSCRIPTION

In 1863, **conscription was introduced for men aged 20–45**. However, those selected could pay for **substitutes to take their place**. Many were also **exempted** for various reasons and large numbers disappeared to **evade conscription**. Only 51,000 conscripts served in the Union army during the war, compared with 118,000 substitutes.

To avert a crisis in 1864, when the initial three-year volunteers reached the end of their term, the government offered **bonus payments and a furlough** (leave) to men who agreed to reenlist. Some **200,000 veteran volunteers stayed in the army**. Cash bonuses were also routinely paid to attract fresh volunteers.

The Union army was as diverse as the society of the states from which the soldiers were drawn. By civilian occupation, farmers and farm laborers were the largest group, making up almost a half of the troops, while skilled workers—carpenters, blacksmiths, shoemakers, machinists, printers—constituted about a quarter of the army. Although, as the war dragged on, recruits were increasingly drawn from the poorer layers of society, only one in seven of the Union soldiers were unskilled laborers. It was a slightly younger army than that of the South, with two out of every five soldiers under 21 years of age. Although the lower age for conscription was 20, many of the substitutes, paid to take the place of unwilling conscripts, were adventurous youths of 18 or 19. Much younger boys served as drummers or buglers, although in 1864 the engagement of children under 16 was officially banned.

Makeup of the Union army

Most striking was the ethnic diversity of the Union forces. About a quarter of those who served in the Union armies were foreign-born,